of political oratory in the vernaculars. In towns across the presidency similar arenas emerged. Another innovation was the public procession, where crowds carried banners and shouted slogans. Poetry too became public, giving itself new content; singing in praise of the motherland and of the downtrodden condition of the people. The poems exhorted the public to mobilize, oppose alien rule and called for the building of a new and freer nation.

The arrival of Bipin Chandra Pal, the Brahmo Samaji and Swadeshi leader of Bengal, in early May 1907, and his series of seven lectures delivered on the Madras beach, electrified the presidency. Pal's speeches inspired many youths and were remembered even a generation later. Educating the common people in the rudiments of nationalist ideology, Pal held up the invincibility of British rule to be *maya*, a mere illusion, which was an eye-opener for many.

Overall, the Swadeshi movement in the Tamil region marked a break in nationalist politics. But the case should not be overstated.[6] Sumit Sarkar, in his astonishingly rich study, bemoans the limitations of the Swadeshi movement in Bengal. While alert to the repressive power of colonial rule, his is a poignant narrative that points to the essentially *bhadralok* nature of the movement; unable to reach out to the vast mass of peasants, it was doomed to fail. Nevertheless, his analytical reconstruction of events between 1903 and 1908 attest to the extraordinary richness of the movement. The breakthroughs made in indigenous production, the boycott of foreign goods, the attempts at expanding national education, the organizing of workers, the fashioning of techniques of mass contact, the creation of *samiti*s—not to mention the cultural efflorescence that it engendered—were the envy of other regions.[7]

A historian looking for this range in the Tamil context would be disappointed. The kind of vigorous advocacy, not to speak of the practice, of 'Swadeshi' which characterized Bengal is absent. Indigenous enterprise in Bengal antedated the Swadeshi movement, and during the course of the movement it received a phenomenal spur. Boycott of foreign goods was more than a slogan, even if it met with limited success. Notable efforts at